which was dependent on .NET Framework and Windows and, as such, had long release cycles.

By contrast, .NET 5+ and hence ASP.NET Core are designed to be released in small increments. Major versions will be released on a predictable cadence, with a new version every year and a new LTS version released every two years (http://mng.bz/1qrg). In addition, bug fixes and minor updates can be released as and when they're needed. Additional functionality is provided in NuGet packages independent of the underlying .NET 5+ platform.

NOTE NuGet is a package manager for .NET that enables you to import libraries into your projects. It's equivalent to Ruby Gems, npm for JavaScript, or Maven for Java.

To enable this approach to releases, ASP.NET Core is highly modular, with as little coupling to other features as possible. This modularity lends itself to a pay-for-play approach to dependencies, where you start with a bare-bones application and add only the libraries you require, as opposed to the kitchen-sink approach of previous ASP.NET applications. Even MVC is an optional package! But don't worry—this approach doesn't mean that ASP.NET Core is lacking in features, only that you need to opt into them. Some of the key infrastructure improvements include

- Middleware pipeline for defining your application's behavior
- Built-in support for dependency injection
- Combined UI (MVC) and API (web API) infrastructure
- Highly extensible configuration system
- Standardized, extensible logging system